

conditions. The calyces are gently tonic and will ease colds, coughs, and chest problems. They also aid digestion and gently stimulate appetite. Both the calyces and flowers act to reduce cholesterol levels. All parts of hibiscus are demulcent, mildly soothing sore or inflamed mucous membranes within the digestive and respiratory tracts.

Research Various clinical studies have shown that hibiscus helps to lower high blood pressure.

Hieracium pilosella syn. *Pilosella officinarum* (Asteraceae)

Mouse-ear Hawkweed

Description Perennial herb growing to a height of 8 in (20 cm) from a rosette of basal leaves. Stems bear single bright yellow flower heads.

Habitat & Cultivation Mouse-ear hawkweed is common throughout much of Europe and temperate regions of Asia and North America. Found growing in dry pastures and on sandy soil, it is collected when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Mouse-ear hawkweed contains a coumarin (umbelliferone), flavonoids, and caffeic acid. It is thought to be mildly antifungal.

History & Folklore In his *Irish Herbal* (1735), K'Eogh summarizes mouse-ear hawkweed's medicinal benefits: "good against the spitting of blood, all kinds of flow, coughs, ulcers of the lungs, mouth and eyes, and shingles."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Mouse-ear hawkweed relaxes the muscles of the bronchial tubes, stimulates the cough reflex, and reduces the production of mucus. This combination of actions makes the herb effective in respiratory problems, including asthma and wheeziness, whooping cough, bronchitis, and other chronic and congested coughs. The herb is used to control heavy menstrual bleeding, and to ease the coughing up of blood. It may be applied as a poultice to heal wounds.

Hippophae rhamnoides (Elaeagnaceae)

Sea Buckthorn

Description Thorny deciduous shrub growing to 16 ft (5 m). Has narrow silvery leaves, male or female flowers, and clusters of brownish-orange berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia, sea buckthorn grows mainly in sandy coastal areas and in dry riverbeds in mountainous regions. The berries are harvested in the autumn.



Sea buckthorn is distinguished by its thorny stems and narrow silvery leaves. The berries help improve the body's resistance to infection.

Parts Used Berries.

Constituents The fruit contains flavonoids, flavones, carotenoids, vitamins A, C (present in very high quantities), and E, and high levels of minerals including sulphur, selenium, zinc, and copper. The seeds contain appreciable levels of alpha-linolenic acid.

History & Folklore The sour-tasting berries have traditionally been eaten with milk and cheese by Siberians and Tartars, who also used them to make a pleasant-tasting jelly.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sea buckthorn berries are very high in vitamin C. They have principally been used to help improve resistance to infection. The berries are mildly astringent, and a decoction of them has been used as a wash to treat skin irritation and eruptions, and to promote healing.

Research Research into sea buckthorn fruit, seed, and seed oil indicates that they have definite therapeutic value. The fruit especially supports heart and circulatory health and is useful in treating conditions such as capillary fragility, arteriosclerosis, and a weak heart. The seed oil nourishes the skin, promotes tissue healing, and will often prove useful in treating eczema.

Hoodia gordonii (Apocynaceae)

Hoodia

Description Unusual-looking succulent growing to 3 ft (1 m), hoodia has multiple spiny, grey-green stems and light purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Kalahari desert, hoodia is now extensively cultivated in Namibia and South Africa. The plant is grown from seed or cuttings. Trade in the hoodia plant is legally restricted due to its threatened survival in the wild.

Parts Used The peeled stem.

Constituents Hoodia contains a steroidal glycoside, which is thought to act as an appetite suppressant.

History & Folklore The San people of the Kalahari traditionally used this plant to suppress sensations of thirst and hunger, when on journeys through the desert. Such use was first recorded in 1937.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Hoodia provides a cautionary tale for herbal medicines and supplements in the 21st century. There is little evidence that taking it leads to weight loss other than the plant's traditional use as an appetite suppressant, while its safety profile is unknown. Despite this, after media coverage by the BBC in 2003, sales of hoodia supplements rocketed, with prices in the *LA Times* reaching \$40 per ounce (30 g) in 2006. At such a price, it is not hard to see why hoodia's survival in the wild is severely threatened. It would seem sensible to opt instead for herbs that are endorsed for their use for weight loss by scientific studies and where there is no risk of the herb disappearing from the wild, such as *Gymnema* (*Gymnema sylvestre*, p. 218).

⚠ Cautions Seek professional advice before taking hoodia products, especially if taking prescribed blood-thinning medication for conditions such as diabetes or high blood pressure.

Hordeum vulgare (Poaceae)

Barley

Description Annual grass growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has an erect hollow stem, lance-shaped leaves, and ears bearing twin rows of seeds and long bristles.

Habitat & Cultivation Barley is cultivated in temperate regions worldwide. It is harvested when the seeds are mature.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents Barley contains polysaccharides, proteins, sugars, fats, and vitamins B and E. The young seedlings also contain the amines tyramine and gramine.

Barley has been eaten since Neolithic times.

